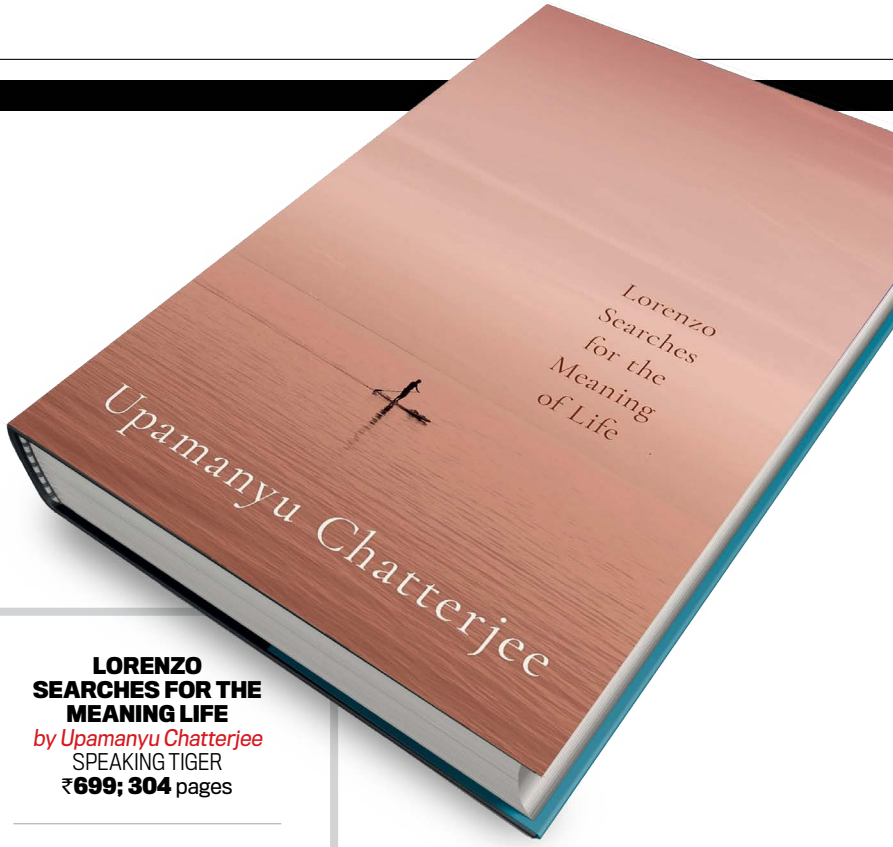


LORENZO SEARCHES FOR THE MEANING LIFE
by Upamanyu Chatterjee
SPEAKING TIGER
₹699; 304 pages

HUMOUR IS USED IN SHORT, SHARP BURSTS, AN EXPLOSION OF IMAGERY AMIDST INWARD-LOOKING PASSAGES

Upamanyu Chatterjee's latest novel, *Lorenzo Searches for the Meaning of Life*, represents a bit of a departure in terms of both form and substance. The 65-year-old writer is known for novels like *English, August* (1988), *The Last Burden* (1993), *Weight Loss* (2006) and, more recently, *The Revenge of the Non-Vegetarian* (2018) and *Villainy* (2022). They are acclaimed for their razor-sharp, sarcasm-laden language, their irony and dark humour, and Chatterjee's wealth of insights about how Indians balance individual and community needs.

His latest novel, however, began life after Chatterjee met his wife's Italian colleague Fabrizio Senesi, a man who had left home to live in a Benedictine monastery in his early 20s, and then worked in a Benedictine 'ashram' in Khulna, Bangladesh. Here was a man who had 'renounced' his regular life to pursue spiritual development, lived as a monk for over two decades, and then returned to the 'regular' world. Chatterjee based *Lorenzo Searches...* on Senesi's experiences, following a chance encounter in the Colombo apartment complex where he lives.

"One day I was in the lift with this Italian gentleman and a lady who was clearly from the subcontinent," Chatterjee recalls. "And they chose to speak Bangla, both of them. Moreover, it was a kind of Bangla that I had not heard since the early '70s, in (Delhi's) Chittaranjan Park, from my parents' friends and acquaintances. The sudden reappearance of this Bangladeshi dialect in my life made me think that this man must have had an unconventional life."

Lorenzo Searches... is, for the most part, soaked in unironic sincerity, as we see an earnest Lorenzo searching for theological answers following a road accident. As Chatterjee shows us, the accident was merely the catalyst. Lorenzo was always going to pursue the religious/ spiritual quests that his mind is preoccupied with for most of the novel. There's an incandescent passage on page 45 where Chatterjee talks about "the pull", the urge to follow spiritual or theological rhetoric to its logical endpoint.

Along the way, Lorenzo draws upon the works of various philosophers and theologists to aid his development and resolve what in his view are discrepancies in his own belief system. He is quite taken with the works of Carlo Carretto, especially *Letters from the Desert*, a line from which becomes his personal motto of sorts: "The desert does not mean the absence of men, it means the presence of God."

"It's a poetic and resonant line and I liked that immediately," says Chatterjee. "The perspective I found intriguing is the idea of God watching you through everything around you. In this framing, the desert is no longer a scary place, it's where you go to introspect and figure out who you are and what you think. I'm told that orthodox religious figures do not like what Carretto propagates, but I find him to be very impressive."

Lorenzo is intrigued by Martin Heidegger, not just because of his provocative ideas but also because the philosopher is difficult to "solve"—he briefly trained to be a Jesuit priest, became a Nazi Party member, was an intellectual powerhouse, a man of seemingly impossible-to-reconcile lives. It's difficult to categorise him neatly, a struggle that begins to mirror Lorenzo's titular search-for-the-meaning-of-life.

"Heidegger is especially important to Lorenzo during his spiritual development," explains Chatterjee. "Out of